Robert McKercher, Economics Ph.D. Candidate, McMaster University

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Research Interests

Public Economics | Labour Economics | Experimental Economics | Taxation | Migration

Education

Ph.D. Economics | McMaster University | Expected completion: June 2027
M.A. Economics | McMaster University | 2021
B.A. Honours Economics with Research Specialization | Wilfrid Laurier University | 2019

Research

Job Market Paper

Taxing Income Splitting within Business-owning Families

Abstract: I examine how business-owning families respond when tax rules restrict dividend-based income splitting. Canada's 2018 expansion of the Tax on Split Income rules raised the tax rate on dividends received by non-exempt spouses of private-business owners. Using linked personal, payroll, and corporate tax records, I compare exposed families with families likely exempt from the reform and exploit differences in pre-reform splitting incentives and simulated tax penalties. The reform reduces dividends reported by exposed spouses by about 53\% relative to controls, while owners report more dividend and employment income. Family taxable income declines much less than spouse dividends, and log tax liability rises modestly. The main response is a reallocation of income reported within the family. Among exposed families, the elasticity of spouse dividends with respect to the pre-reform splitting incentive is similar across income quartiles. This differs from the conventional elasticity of taxable income but suggests that access to tax-planning channels helps shape measured tax responsiveness. For a given increase in the simulated tax penalty, tax liability rises more in percentage terms among moderate-income families than among those in the highest income quartile. Families facing the largest total penalties show the clearest decline in family taxable income and increase in tax liability.

Working Papers

Should I Stay or Should I Go? The Impact of Taxation on Canadian Inter-Provincial Migration
with Adam M. Lavecchia and Alisa Tazhitdinova
Reject and Resubmit, Journal of Public Economics (July 2026)

The Impact of Government Social Spending on the Elasticity of Taxable Income

Labour Supply Responses to Marginal Tax Rates, Average Tax Rates, and Tax Progressivity
with Li-Hsin Lin

Poverty and Income Security in Canada: Designing a Canada-Wide Guaranteed Basic Income Using the PEI Proposal
with Robin Boadway, Kourtney Koebel, and Wayne Simpson

Conference Presentations

Should I Stay or Should I Go? The Impact of Taxation on Canadian Inter-Provincial Migration
Canadian Economic Association Annual Conference, Vancouver, British Columbia | May 2026

The Impact of Government Social Spending on the Elasticity of Taxable Income
Canadian Economic Association Annual Conference, Toronto, Ontario | May 2024

Research Experience

Research Assistant to Kourtney Koebel | University of Toronto | September 2026–Present
Research Assistant to Adam M. Lavecchia | McMaster University | 2021–2025
Research Assistant to Siha Lee | McMaster University | 2023
Research Assistant to Bradley Ruffle | McMaster University | 2022

Teaching Experience

Instructor | McMaster University | Winter 2025
Intermediate Microeconomics II (EC2ZZ3)

Teaching Assistant | McMaster University | 2020–Present
Introductory Microeconomics; Introductory Macroeconomics; Intermediate Microeconomics I & II; Environmental Economics; Public Sector Economics: Taxation; International Monetary Economics; Labour Economics; Behavioural Economics

Awards, Grants, Scholarships

David S. Daly Academic Grant | 2025–2026
Ontario Graduate Scholarship | 2024–2025
General Bursary | 2023–2024 & 2024–2025
McMaster Economics Graduate Scholarship | 2020–2025

Technical Skills

Stata | Fortran | Python | R

References

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